

NamingContest.com — Platform Guide

Plain-English guide for running and testing the platform

The plain-English guide. No technical knowledge needed. There is a separate Developer Handbook for whoever maintains the code.

What the platform does

NamingContest lets anyone run a naming contest end to end:

1. **Create** — pick a category (Personal, Group, or Business), answer a short guided brief, and set the rules: how names are credited, how many names each person can submit (1 to 5), and how long each phase runs.
2. **Pay** — a one-time fee based on how many voters you invite: \$9 for up to 10, \$19 for up to 30, \$39 for up to 90. No subscription.
3. **Collect names** — share one invitation link. Participants join with just their email (a sign-in link, no passwords anywhere on the platform).
4. **Vote** — when the submission window closes, voting opens automatically. Everyone picks up to three favourites. Vote counts stay hidden until the end.
5. **Crown a winner** — the creator picks from the leaderboard, everyone gets the announcement email, and there is a public result page to share.

Everything moves on its own timers. Nobody has to flip switches.

The five services behind it

All five use the same login (credentials shared privately, never in documents).

SERVICE	WHAT IT DOES	WHEN YOU'D LOG IN
Vercel	Hosts the website	To see visitor analytics
Supabase	Database, accounts, server logic	Rarely; mostly a developer tool
Stripe	Takes the payments	To see sales and issue refunds
Resend	Sends the emails	To check an email was delivered
GitHub	Stores the code	Developer only

Trying the platform (beta)

1. Go to **namingcontest.com** and enter the beta password.
2. Create a contest as a real user would. At checkout use Stripe's test card: **4242 4242 4242 4242**, any future expiry, any 3-digit code, any ZIP. It behaves exactly like a real charge, but no money moves.
3. When setting the timeline, pick the **shortest windows: 3 days for submissions and 2 days for voting**. The contest then completes on its own in 5 days. (Phases switch automatically on those timers. Moving a contest between phases by hand requires database access and can break it, so short timers are the safe way to experience the full flow.)
4. To experience the participant side, open your own invitation link in a **private browser window** and join with a second email address. That second address will receive everything a real participant gets.

The emails the platform sends

All custom-designed to match the site, each in the contest's own colour theme.

EMAIL	WHO GETS IT	WHEN
Sign-in link	Anyone logging in	Every sign-in (no passwords)
"Your contest is live" + Stripe receipt	The creator	Right after payment
"Your vote is needed"	All participants	The moment voting opens
"Time to crown the winner"	The creator only	The moment voting closes
"The winning name"	All participants	When a winner is crowned
"Your name won"	The winner personally	Same moment
Contact form receipt	Whoever wrote in	Right after sending

A creator who pays without being signed in gets **one** email, not two: the receipt's "Go to your contest" button signs them in and takes them straight there, so there is no separate sign-in message to hunt for.

Gmail sometimes places one in the Promotions tab. This improves on its own as the domain builds sending reputation over the first weeks of real use.

Checking payments in Stripe

1. Log in to **dashboard.stripe.com**.
2. Make sure the **Test mode** toggle (top right) is ON while we're in beta.
3. Open **Payments** — every test checkout appears there like a real sale, with the amount, the card, and the contest it belongs to.

When we go live, a developer switches the test keys for live keys (about ten minutes of work). Everything is already connected; real charging is simply disabled until then.

A note on reliability. Payments are confirmed twice over. The browser confirms the card and the platform then verifies that payment directly with Stripe before the contest goes live, so nothing can go live without a real payment. Separately, Stripe notifies the platform of every successful payment on its own channel, which covers the rare case where someone's browser closes or loses connection in the second after paying. Without that, the money would be taken and the contest would never start. Whichever arrives first completes the launch and the other does nothing, so nobody is charged twice or emailed twice.

Visitor statistics

Vercel Analytics is installed on the site. In **Vercel → the project → Analytics** you can see visitors, page views, top pages, countries, and devices. It's privacy-friendly (no cookies), so no consent banner is needed.

Before public launch — your checklist

1. **Set up the hello@namingcontest.com mailbox.** The contact form currently sends the visitor a receipt, but the message itself has nowhere to land because no mailbox exists yet. Five minutes in eNom — see the steps below.
2. **Create the real social media profiles** (X, LinkedIn, Instagram). The icons in the email footers currently point at placeholder handles.
3. **Replace the landing page testimonials** with real ones.
4. **Senior developer review** — one error-and-safety pass before launch.

5. **Switch Stripe to live keys** — a developer task with a step-by-step checklist in the Going Live guide, done last, just before launch.

Setting up the mailbox in eNom

1. Log in to eNom and open **Domains → My Domains → namingcontest.com**.
2. Open **Email Settings** (sometimes called **Email Forwarding**).
3. Add a forward: **hello@** → the inbox where you want messages to arrive (your Catchword address works fine).
4. Save. eNom adds the necessary mail records automatically.
5. Send a test email to hello@namingcontest.com and confirm it arrives.

Two things not to touch while you're in there: - Never change the **nameservers**. That would take the website offline. - Don't edit or delete any existing records mentioning **resend** or **send.namingcontest.com** — those run the platform's outgoing email.

What's safe to do yourself vs. what needs a developer

Safe: browsing every dashboard, viewing payments in Stripe, viewing email deliveries in Resend, viewing analytics in Vercel, running contests on the site itself.

Needs a developer: anything in Supabase's SQL editor, changing environment variables or keys, editing code, changing DNS beyond the mailbox steps above. The platform protects itself against most mistakes, but database changes can't always be undone.

Getting help

Bugs and questions during the beta go to Matt. After handoff, the Developer Handbook and the Going Live guide (separate documents) give a maintainer everything needed to run, fix, extend, and launch the platform.